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Illinois cracks down on ‘nurdles’

Law makes state the first in Great Lakes region to designate industrial plastic pellets as pollution

By Michael Hawthorne
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Illinois is requiring polluters to begin reporting spills of industrial plastic pellets known as nurdles, a growing source of contamination in the Great Lakes and Mississippi River watersheds.

Companies that manufacture, use or transport nurdles also must

develop plans to limit them in storm runoff, making the state the first in either watershed to officially designate bits of wasted plastic as pollution.

The new law, signed late last week by Gov. JB Pritzker, comes as an ongoing Tribune series, “Great Waste in the Great Lakes,” delves into threats posed by nurdles and other man-made particles known

collectively as microplastics.

Nurdles, synthesized by petrochemical plants as building blocks of new plastics, have been found in every Great Lake and in rivers throughout Illinois.

Light enough to travel long distances through the air, nurdles routinely spill from chemical plants that make them, trains and trucks that transport them and factories that turn them into consumer products, the Tribune has found.

See **NURDLES** on Page A2



Emily Kowalski, associate director at Environment Illinois, looks at a container of industrial plastic pellets known as nurdles found along the Wild Mile in the Chicago River’s North Branch on Monday. **ANTONIO PEREZ/TRIBUNE**

Trump deflects growing AI anxiety

Many voters fret, but president promotes technology, data sites

By Tony Romm
THE NEW YORK TIMES

WASHINGTON — The rapid rise of artificial intelligence has started to rattle voters around the country, raising fears that they could be thrust from their jobs if the technology succeeds, or lose their retirement savings if the industry falters.

But for all of the emerging doubt and political blowback, there has been no sign of concern at the White House, where President Donald Trump has generally maintained a much more sanguine view about the coming digital revolution.

To the administration, AI can do little wrong.

In recent weeks, Trump and his top aides have dismissed the suggestion that widespread automation could carry real negative consequences for families, businesses and the broader U.S. economy.

Even as the electorate grows uneasy about the technology — and the data centers that power it — the president has only hardened in his view that AI will supercharge everything from medical research to military action.

The political chasm between the president and the public has been most evident surrounding the red-hot issue of data centers, which Trump has defended as “Money Machines” even as opposition widens nationally over the facilities.

A small group of demonstrators interrupted one of Trump’s rallies in Michigan last month to demand an end to data center construction. That incident came on the heels of similar protests around the country, in a campaign organized by

See **AI** on Page A8

INSIDE

Family sues over fatal police shooting

The family of a man fatally shot by police five months ago is suing the city and the shooting officer, alleging the officer was excessive and unreasonable in his use of deadly force. **Chicagoland, A3**

The MVP debate: PCA vs. Ohtani

Advanced metrics favor the Cubs’ Pete Crow-Armstrong, but Ohtani’s historic success as a DH and pitcher give both sides arguments in National League MVP race. **Chicago Sports**



Gov. JB Pritzker, left, greets people at an Illinois Farm Bureau event in Shirley on Monday. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE PHOTOS**

ELECTION 2026 ILLINOIS GOVERNOR

Pritzker, Bailey spar over tariffs, farming economy

Governor candidates discuss issues at agricultural roundtable in Shirley

By Jeremy Gorner
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

SHIRLEY, Ill. — Democratic Gov. JB Pritzker and his Republican opponent in the governor’s race, Darren Bailey, sought to woo Illinois’ agriculture industry Monday, with Bailey, a veteran farmer, accusing the two-term Democrat of hating President Donald Trump “more than he loves Illinois” and Pritzker blaming the Trump administration for the economic strain on the state’s farmers.

Speaking for nearly an hour

at an agriculture industry event in rural central Illinois, Pritzker blamed the war in Iran and ongoing trade disputes for driving up the cost of fertilizer, diesel and other farming expenses — but he broke from his usual criticism of Trump to agree with the president’s call for oil companies to return some war-driven profits to consumers.

“Strangely, even though everyone else is suffering from all of this, the big oil companies announce that they’re raking in record prof-

See **ELECTION** on Page A4



Republican gubernatorial nominee Darren Bailey greets people at the Illinois Farm Bureau event in Shirley.

CPD expands domestic violence assistance

Aim is to meet victims where they are, link them to resources

By Sam Charles
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

It’s the most common 911 call in Chicago. Across the city every day, more than 50 calls are placed to report a domestic battery.

The frequency has largely held steady since the abatement of the COVID-19 pandemic — roughly

21,000 domestic battery reports every year, records show — though Chicago police officers have in recent years upped the number of domestic violence arrests.

Now the Chicago Police Department aims to deepen its response to domestic violence with the Office of Equity Engagement, established last year as a new prong in the department’s ongoing consent decree reform efforts.

CPD is expanding its Victim Services Program within the Office of Equity Engagement in

the hopes of connecting more crime victims — especially those affected by domestic violence and nonfatal shootings — to housing and other resource assistance via a growing number of CPD advocates and caseworkers.

“We always want to meet the victim where they’re at,” Michael Milstein, deputy director of CPD’s Office of Equity and Engagement, said in a recent interview. “We’re never going to tell a victim, ‘Well, we can’t provide you any more services, we’re done with you.’ It’s

really based on what that individual needs and how they want to engage with us.”

In 2025, advocates and caseworkers — 51 of them — were in contact with and provided some level of assistance to more than 7,100 victims, according to a recent internal report.

CPD is not trying to be a long-term service provider, but instead serve as a connector for victims and service organizations, lead-

See **VICTIMS** on Page A8

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WEATHER FORECAST

TODAY H: 80 L: 70
WED. H: 81 L: 69
THU. H: 78 L: 68
Complete details on Page A12

INDEX

Almanac A8
Arts & Living B7
Comics B10-B11
Crossword B11
Editorials A5
Horoscope B10
Nation & World B4
Obituaries A8
Television B9

179th year No. 223
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